

Sins of the FATHERS

A nun's sensational book exposes sexual exploitation and other sordid details from the Church in Kerala

| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

Amen" is the concluding word for prayers. There is also another meaning, "So be it". The latter is probably what inspired Sister Jesme, a senior nun from the Kerala Church, to release her sensational autobiography titled *Amen* which has caused a shockwave of Tsunami-like proportions. The book contains lurid descriptions of sexual perversions performed on her by priests and fellow nuns. The scandal has been magnified because it involves the all-powerful Catholic Church in a state with a large Christian population which supplies about 60 per cent of the country's priests and nuns. Three weeks after Sister Jesme, 53, released her lurid autobiography, the state is still reeling from the revelations.

Never has the dark underbelly of the church been so starkly exposed, with the nun's sordid tales of sexual exploitation, lesbianism, petty rivalries and patriarchy. The Malayalam

book *Amen: The Autobiography of a Nun* was an instant bestseller and is printing its third edition within a month. Publishers are vying for translation rights and movie companies are queuing up outside her tiny rented flat in Kozhikode where she moved after her resignation from the Congregation of Mother of Carmel (CMC) where she served for 33 years. "I never knew there would be so much interest in the trivial life of a humble nun," said Sister Jesme.

Her story is anything but trivial. The narrative is full of instances when she was forced into lesbian relations by senior nuns or sexual liaisons by priests. "Lesbianism is rampant among nuns. There are also innumerable instances of nuns having sexual relations with priests or outsiders. This is in a community where we were brought up looking at all this as grave sins," she says.

Her revelations are even more shocking considering that the nuns

SISTER JESME
WITH HER
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THESE REVELATIONS ARE MORE SHOCKING SINCE THE NUNS OF KERALA FORM A SIGNIFICANT SECTION OF THE GLOBAL CHRISTIAN FAMILY.

of Kerala form a significant section in the global Christian family. Last October, a Kerala nun—Saint Alphonsa—became the first Indian woman to be canonised by the Pope at the Vatican. Lately, however, it is the dark side that has made headlines (*see box*). Incidence of suicides by nuns too has been on the rise. Recently, the state Women's Commission issued guidelines to end the exploitation and miseries of nuns, the "silent section in the church", which were